

combat communism in the Third World by counterinsurgency support for anticommunist regimes.

The Bay of Pigs fiasco, a CIA-backed invasion of Cuba planned by the previous administration, was a major setback. Kennedy authorized the invasion in the first 100 days of his presidency, but then refused to give it his full support. Sensing that the new president was inexperienced and irresolute, Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev took the offensive, building the Berlin Wall in summer 1961 and then agreeing to Cuban president Fidel Castro's request to station nuclear missiles in Cuba.

The resulting Cuban Missile Crisis in October 1962 was Kennedy's finest hour. Resisting pressure for an attack on Cuba, he negotiated the withdrawal of Soviet weaponry, a diplomatic victory that led to progress in reducing nuclear tensions between the superpowers.

“Freedom is indivisible, and when one man is enslaved, all are not free.”

PRESIDENT JOHN F. KENNEDY, SPEECH IN WEST BERLIN, JUNE 26, 1963

Policy in Vietnam

In Southeast Asia, Kennedy backed a counterinsurgency strategy spearheaded by the Green Berets, a policy that expressed his desire to halt the spread of communism while also avoiding outright warfare. He was initially in favor of fellow Catholic Ngo Dinh Diem's presidency of South Vietnam, but became disillusioned with Diem's failure to win the hearts and minds of his people. By 1963, America faced a stark choice: lose Vietnam to communism or reinforce its military presence there. Neither option was attractive to Kennedy. His hesitations were evident by the time of the US-backed assassination of Diem. Whether the war in Vietnam would have been radically different but for Kennedy's own assassination cannot be known.